

Do This When Starting A Business

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Executive Summary

Leverage the "Richard Branson trick" — give top-tier companies free work or exposure to earn a credible association, then use that name recognition to land real paying clients and sponsorships.

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The Richard Branson Trick Explained 0:00

- Branson was launching a new, unproven magazine and kept getting rejected by advertisers
 - Companies said the magazine was "new, low-level" and not who they wanted to be associated with
- His solution: call a major brand (Coca-Cola) and offer them **double-page spreads for free**
 - When asked "what's the catch?", he was fully transparent:
 - "By having you in my magazine, everyone will think we work together — you get free exposure, I get future business. Sound fair?"
 - Coca-Cola agreed
- Next edition, he called other companies who initially said no
 - When asked "who have you worked with?", he said: "Coca-Cola — here's the magazine, go pick it up off the shelf"
 - Prospects would find the double-page spread and immediately change their answer: "Okay, you've worked with Coca-Cola — we'll work with you"

The entire strategy hinges on one borrowed credibility moment: get one big name on record, then use it as social proof to unlock everyone else.

Choosing the Right Companies to Target 1:08

- Do NOT give free work to low-level or weak companies
 - Your goal is association with quality — the partner's reputation transfers to you

- Be aware that some high-end companies will reject free offers
 - Their reasoning: "We only pay for the best — free signals low quality to us"
 - This means you need to find a "middle bracket" — reputable but accessible brands willing to accept the trade
- Honesty is emphasised as a core tactic in every pitch
 - "Be completely honest with them" — transparency disarms skepticism and builds trust faster than a polished sales pitch



Real-World Examples: Mirafit & Barcelona FC 1:31

- **Mirafit gym equipment sponsorship**
 - Onem negotiated a discounted deal (not fully free) in exchange for brand visibility in videos
 - Total equipment cost: ~£25,000; flooring was the single most expensive item
 - Value exchange pitched to Mirafit: logo visible in video backgrounds → audience exposure → likely product purchases
 - Result: Onem is now publicly associated with Mirafit as a brand partner
- **Barcelona FC VIP seats**
 - Noticed Barcelona was **€2 billion in debt** — identified this as a leverage/opportunity point
 - Negotiated **4 VIP season seats for 24,000 euros** in the Camp Nou stadium (seats go live at the start of the season when the stadium renovation completes)
 - The Onem logo will appear on those seats inside the Barcelona stadium
 - Framed as "the Richard Branson trick on steroids" — spending a modest amount to attach the brand to a globally recognised institution



How to Apply This Today 2:15

- The core action: approach companies and simply offer to do work for them — even unsolicited
 - Don't just ask "can I work for you?" — go further: produce something and hand it over
 - "They might end up using it. If they use it, you've now worked with them."
- Steps to execute the strategy:
 - Identify a credible, mid-to-high-tier brand in your industry that is accessible
 - Pitch a transparent value exchange — be explicit about what you get (association/credibility) and what they get (free work/exposure)
 - Deliver the work; get it in front of their audience or attached to their name
 - Use that association in every subsequent pitch to new prospects
 - Repeat with progressively bigger names as credibility compounds
- Key mindset: "It's so simple but nobody wants to do it" — the barrier is psychological, not logistical
 - Most people won't do free work; that reluctance is exactly what creates the opportunity for those who will